

Background

For the past 25 years, the Autumn Harvest Festival has served as the region's signature seasonal event, drawing both locals and visitors from neighboring counties.

Held each fall over four weekends, the festival operates on Saturdays and Sundays from 10:00 AM to 8:00 PM. Guests enjoy a mix of food and beverage offerings, artisan merchandise vendors, and family-friendly activities throughout the festival grounds.

Attendance has increased over time, transforming the festival from a small community gathering into a regional destination. To support growing demand, festival organizers manage a diverse mix of vendor booths and entertainment experiences while balancing operational capacity, guest satisfaction, and financial performance.

This year (2026) marks the festival's 25th anniversary, and organizers anticipate higher attendance than in previous years as both longtime guests and new visitors are expected to join the milestone celebration. Festival leadership expects attendance to exceed historical growth trends but has not determined by how much.

The anniversary celebration is expected to attract additional guests through increased marketing efforts, special entertainment offerings, and heightened community interest. As part of the celebration, organizers are evaluating both short-term operational decisions and long-term growth opportunities to ensure the festival can continue to accommodate future demand while maintaining a high-quality guest experience.

Part 1

Develop a forecast for total attendance for this year's festival and for each festival weekend (and identify the expected peak weekend). You may provide low, expected, and high attendance scenarios to account for forecasting uncertainty.

Please clearly explain your methodology and assumptions.

Historical Festival Attendance

YEAR	TOTAL ATTENDANCE
2021	49,000
2022	48,500
2023	50,000
2024	53,500
2025	56,000

Typical Attendance Distribution by Weekend

WEEKEND	% OF TOTAL ATTENDANCE
1	20%

2	25%
3	30%
4	25%

Additional Information

- Marketing spend has increased 20% compared to 2025
- Historically, the festival's advertising efforts have primarily targeted the local metropolitan area, which has a population of approximately 500,000 residents. This year, the marketing campaign *WDPR Fall 2026 IE Case Study* has expanded to include neighboring metropolitan areas, increasing the total advertising reach to approximately 1.2 million residents
- An anniversary concert (new for the 25th anniversary milestone) will be offered during Weekend 4. The concert venue will have a maximum capacity of 8,000 and will be free with general festival admission.

Part 2

Based on your attendance forecast, recommend the number of vendor booths that should be offered in each category below. Your recommendation should balance guest experience, revenue generation, variety of offerings, and operational feasibility.

- Food & Beverage
- Merchandise
- Activities & Experiences

Additional Information

- Maximum standard booth equivalents: 120
- Activities & Experiences booths require twice as much as space standard-sized Food & Beverage or Merchandise booths
- The following historical averages may be used as a starting point:

CATEGORY	TYPICAL SPEND PER TRANSACTION	TYPICAL OPERATING COST	% OF GUESTS PARTICIPATING	SPACE REQUIREMENT
Food & Beverage	\$18-\$25	High	70-85%	1
Merchandise	\$12-\$20	Medium	25-40%	1
Activities & Experiences	\$5-\$12	Low-Medium	30-50%	2

Part 3

Festival leadership is considering the following options to accommodate future growth:

- Option A: Extend operating hours from 10 hours per day to 12 hours per day •
- Option B: Add Friday operations to each festival weekend
- Option C: Add a fifth festival weekend

Recommend which option should be pursued and justify your recommendation using operational, financial, and guest experience considerations.

Please provide your team's recommendations for the above questions in a PowerPoint presentation to be shared with festival leadership. Supporting documents may be included but are not required.

Ensure your team provides thorough explanations of your ideas and the assumptions you used that lead to your recommendations. You are welcome to use the internet and public information in addition to your own educated assumptions to inform your decisions. No additional information will be provided.

Criteria to be reviewed & rated:

- Presentation, format and quality of slides
- Structure and organization
- Strategic thinking and analysis